

1980-1991

THE COLLAPSE OF THE SOVIET EMPIRE

The “iron curtain” – an ideological and military barrier established by the Soviet Union – had separated Europe’s Communist and non-Communist states since the end of World War II. By the early 1980s, however, the Soviet economy was failing and the urgent need for reform drove the Politburo to appoint Mikhail Gorbachev as its new leader in 1985. His policy of *glasnost* or openness only served to expose deep veins of resentment at the system and its failings. Ungagged by the lifting of censorship, liberals in the USSR’s satellites began to speak out for greater freedom. First,

Poland’s Solidarity trade union gained public support, then the Baltic republics demanded self-government, and in January 1989 the Hungarian parliament allowed the formation of opposition parties.

In November of that year, the Berlin Wall fell, followed by Communist regimes in Romania and the Czech Republic. By the end of 1989, Lithuania, Poland, and East Germany had taken the same route. In 1991, the liberal nationalist Boris Yeltsin became president of Russia, and in December that year the Soviet Union was formally dissolved.



KEY MOMENTS

22 December 1989 Fall of Ceaușescu

Nicolai Ceaușescu was Romania’s Soviet-backed head of state for two decades, presiding over an increasingly repressive regime and a steadily worsening economy. On 17 December 1989, he ordered police to open fire on demonstrators in western Romania; protest and unrest (*left*) followed in the capital Bucharest. Ceaușescu tried to flee the country, but was arrested and executed.



29 December 1989 The Velvet Revolution

In the Czech Republic, a non-violent protest movement that came to be known as the Velvet Revolution overthrew the old Soviet-backed regime. Its figurehead was the playwright Václav Havel (*left*), who had spent lengthy terms in prison under Communist rule. Havel took over the nation’s presidency, negotiating the removal of Soviet troops from the country and organizing free elections for 1990.

